



WITS AHEAD RESEARCH GROUP

The AHEAD Fortnightly

Issue 0 (launch preview) · 12 September 2026 · Wits School of Education, University of the Witwatersrand

Welcome to the launch preview of The AHEAD Fortnightly, the Wits AHEAD Research Group's digest of what the world has been saying about artificial intelligence, analytics, data and human capability in higher education. Every second Thursday from 1 October 2026 it will land in subscribers' inboxes at 07:00, never longer than two pages, drawn from the daily briefing on our website. Every item is checked against its source; the summaries are our own, and each carries a note on why it matters to the group's remit.

THREE THINGS TO KNOW

1

NEWS · SEPTEMBER 2026 · UNITED KINGDOM

University of Leicester gives Microsoft 365 Copilot to all 21,000 students and 4,000 staff

From September 2026 every student and staff member at Leicester has full Copilot access across Microsoft 365, paired with mandatory digital-skills modules completed in Blackboard before access opens. Manchester announced a similar whole-institution rollout in January.

Why it matters: Whole-institution AI provision changes the baseline for academic integrity, assessment design and equity of access. It is a live test case for Pillar 1 and a benchmark South African universities will be measured against.

University of Leicester · le.ac.uk · [Read at source](#)

2

REPORT · AUGUST 2026 · SOUTH AFRICA

Youth unemployment (15 to 34) rises to 47.4% in the second quarter of 2026

The official youth unemployment rate increased by 1.5 percentage points to 47.4% in Q2 2026. Unemployed youth rose by 264,000 to 5.0 million while employed youth fell by 40,000 to 5.6 million.

Why it matters: This is the single defensible figure the group uses for graduate pathways and just transitions. Pillar 4 asks how AI reshapes the route from qualification to livelihood for exactly this cohort.

Statistics South Africa, Quarterly Labour Force Survey Q2 2026 · statssa.gov.za · [Read at source](#)

3

REPORT · 4 AUGUST 2026 · GLOBAL

World Development Report 2026: The Promise of Artificial Intelligence

The Bank's first dedicated assessment of AI for low- and middle-income countries, framed as adopt, adapt, advance. Middle-income countries made up half of ChatGPT's traffic within six months of launch, faster diffusion than any earlier general-purpose technology, yet the report sets out the electricity, connectivity and data conditions that must be met before AI improves public services.

Why it matters: The report is the policy frame funders will use for the next five years. AHEAD's Global South, capability-first stance is a direct response to its adopt-adapt-advance agenda.

World Bank · worldbank.org · [Read at source](#)

RESEARCH AND REPORTS

Still emerging: understanding generative AI use in higher education

Frontiers in Education, peer-reviewed · July 2026 · Pillar 1: Generative AI in higher education. Useful comparator for the group's own bibliometric and survey work under Pillar 1.

Reframing AI and learning analytics in emerging higher education: towards a human-centred, contextually responsive future

Frontiers in Education, peer-reviewed scoping review · June 2026 · Pillar 6: Responsible AI and policy. The review's Global South frame and its human-centred thesis are AHEAD's own. It is a reference point for the group's positioning papers and a map of collaborators.

2026 Future of Jobs Summit puts AI reskilling at the centre of South Africa's employment debate

IOL Business Report · 28 May 2026 · Pillar 4: Graduate capability and just transitions. Employers are redefining employability in real time. Pillar 4 reframes that demand as capability for work and life, not only a skills list.

UC Berkeley Law bans generative AI on all graded work from Summer 2026

UC Berkeley School of Law policy; reported in Forbes · 22 May 2026 · Pillar 1: Generative AI in higher education. The opposite pole to Leicester. Together they bracket the design space for assessment and integrity policy that Pillar 1 studies, and they show why evidence, not instinct, should decide.

WATCH

► 'Don't walk alone': Prof. Mwenda Ntarangwi on collaboration, AI and the future of African higher education (14 min)

The Education Collaborative, with the Vice-Chancellor of USIU-Africa. Recorded at the Collaborative's Kigali convening ahead of its Nairobi East Africa Hub meeting in October 2026: collaboration, hub progress and technology's role in African higher education.

► Are graduates prepared for the AI era? (19 min)

Financial Times, Working It. Working It editor Isabel Berwick looks at how institutions worldwide are helping graduates into first jobs, and the tools and skills that now drive a successful search.

FROM THE GROUP

12 Sep 2026 Daily briefing launched on the Wits AHEAD website

News, research, video and readings on the group's remit, curated every morning and archived.

A READING WE PROFFER

Development as Freedom Amartya Sen, Oxford University Press (1999). The H in AHEAD. Start here.

With best wishes for the fortnight ahead,

Director: Wits AHEAD

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